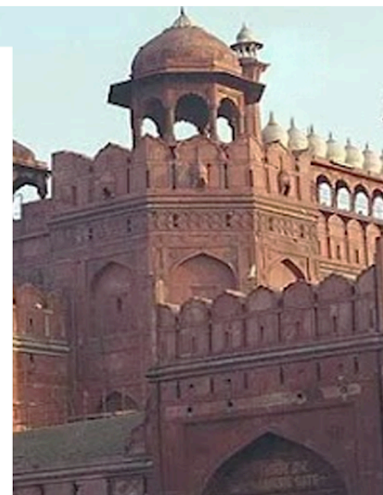
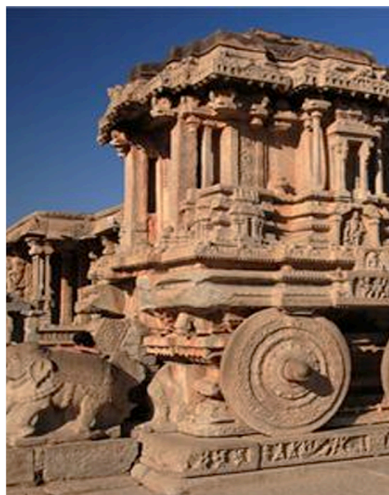


General Knowledge

Medieval History

STUDY NOTES

Saints of Maharashtra



Saints of Maharashtra



Bhakti Movement in Maharashtra

Between the 13th and 17th centuries, Maharashtra saw a flourishing Bhakti movement, with poet-saints composing hymns and devotional poems in simple Marathi. These saints promoted devotion to a personal god residing within the hearts of people, challenging caste-based discrimination and social injustices.

- Shri Vitthal-Rukmini Mandir in Pandharpur became the spiritual centre for the Bhakti saints.
- Saints like Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Eknath, and Tukaram emphasized self-realization through devotion (Bhakti) rather than ritualism and promoted equality.

Prominent Saints of Maharashtra and Their Teachings

Saint	Period	Teachings and Contributions
Sant Dnyaneshwar (Jnanadeva)	1275–1296 CE	- Belonged to the Nath tradition (Shiva as the first guru). - Wrote Dnyaneshwari, a Marathi commentary on the Bhagavad Gita. - Composed Amrutanubhav, a philosophical treatise on non-duality.

Namdev	1270–1350 CE	- Part of the Varkari sect. - His hymns are included in the Guru Granth Sahib. - Promoted family life as the path to Moksha (self-realization). - Emphasized marriage and social harmony.
Sant Eknath	1533–1599 CE	- Spiritual successor of Dnyaneshwar and Namdev. - Belonged to the Varkari cult. - Wrote Eknathi Bhagavata, Bhavarth Ramayana, and Rukmini Swayamwar. - Emphasized compassion and tolerance.
Sant Tukaram	17th century	- A worshipper of Vithoba. - Opposed ritualism and rejected monastic life. - Promoted humanism, saying that Bhakti lies in sharing others' pain. - His Abhangas (devotional poems) express spiritual devotion and social reform.
Chokhamela	14th century	- Belonged to the Mahar caste and was a devotee of Vithoba. - Wrote Abhangas like "<i>Abir Gulal Udhlit Rang</i>", expressing devotion and social protest. - His poems highlighted the suffering of the lower castes.
Soyarabai	Wife of Chokhamela	- Wrote blank verses expressing grief over untouchability. - Addressed herself as "Chokha's Mahari" and questioned God for the injustices faced by untouchables.
Nirmala	Sister of Chokhamela	- Composed Abhangas highlighting the injustices and inequality she experienced. - Her poems reflect personal suffering caused by the caste system.

Sakkubai	Devotee of Vithoba	- Born into a Brahmin family and faced abuse from her in-laws. - Known for her unwavering devotion to Vithoba despite personal suffering.
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Philosophy of the Saints of Maharashtra

- Devotion over Ritualism: Saints like Tukaram and Namdev refuted outward displays of religiosity and focused on internal devotion.
- Personal God: They believed in a personal god residing in the hearts of people (Vithoba/Vitthal).
- Equality and Social Reform: Saints like Chokhamela and Soyarabai spoke against caste discrimination and emphasized social justice.
- Humanism and Compassion: Tukaram emphasized compassion and shared suffering as the essence of Bhakti.
- Integration with Daily Life: Saints advocated family life and considered marriage as an important institution for spiritual progress.

The Varkari Tradition and Pandharpur Pilgrimage

- The Varkari sect worships Vithoba (Vitthal), and its followers undertake pilgrimages to Pandharpur.
- Key Principles of Varkari Tradition:
 - Simple living and devotion to God.
 - Equality of all people, regardless of caste or social status.
 - Bhakti through Abhangas (devotional songs).

The Role of Women in the Bhakti Movement

- Soyarabai and Nirmala addressed gender and caste inequalities in their verses.
- Sakkubai, despite personal suffering, showed unwavering devotion to Vithoba.
- Akka Mahadevi in Karnataka and Mirabai in North India share similar stories of devotional perseverance.

Impact of the Bhakti Movement in Maharashtra

1. **Social Equality:** Saints challenged caste hierarchies and untouchability, promoting spiritual equality.
2. **Literary Development:** The Abhangas and devotional literature enriched Marathi literature.
3. **Inspiration for Social Reform:** The teachings of these saints inspired later social reformers like Mahatma Gandhi.
4. **Unity in Diversity:** Their inclusiveness and universal love helped bridge differences between Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs.
5. **Spiritual Awakening:** The saints emphasized the importance of inner spirituality, accessible to all, beyond rituals and formal practices.

Other Prominent Saints during the Bhakti Movement in Maharashtra

Name	Location	Key Features and Contributions
Ramdas Swami (1608-1681)	Jamb, Satara District	- Spiritual guide to Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. - Founded Samarth Sampradaya. - Wrote Dasbodh and Manache Shlok emphasizing self-discipline and righteous living.
Gora Kumbhar	Ter, Osmanabad District	- A potter by profession, known for his unwavering devotion to Vitthala. - His life reflects surrender to God's will despite personal tragedies.
Bahina Bai (1628-1700)	Dehu, Pune District	- A female Varkari poet devoted to Tukaram and Vitthala. - Wrote Abhangas describing spiritual experiences and social struggles. - Emphasized equality and devotion beyond caste and gender.

Narhari Sonar	Pandharpur, Solapur District	- A goldsmith and devotee of Vitthala. - Known for the legend where Vitthala appeared in his workshop to test his devotion.
Sant Kanhopatra	Pandharpur	- A courtesan's daughter who renounced her past and devoted herself to Vitthala. - Known for her Abhangas expressing a yearning for divine love.
Janardan Swami (1504-1575)	Nasik, Maharashtra	- A Shaivite ascetic and spiritual teacher of Eknath. - Known for promoting the integration of Shaivism and Bhakti traditions.
Bhanudas (1448-1513)	Pandharpur	- Played a crucial role in reviving the Vithoba temple at Pandharpur. - His poetry reflects deep devotion to Vitthala and social harmony.
Vithabai	Pandharpur	- A female saint devoted to Vithoba, belonging to the Varkari sect. - Known for her simple devotional poems advocating spiritual equality.
Nivruttinath	Alandi, Pune District	- Elder brother of Sant Dnyaneshwar. - Initiated into the Nath tradition, combining Shaivism with Bhakti. - Guided Dnyaneshwar in his spiritual journey.
Visoba Khechar	Pandharpur	- A disciple of Namdev. - Known for promoting Vithoba worship and bridging caste divisions.